

Does an Ironhack UX/UI bootcamp make you a "high-paid UX designer"?

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A data look at the outcomes Ironhack itself publishes.

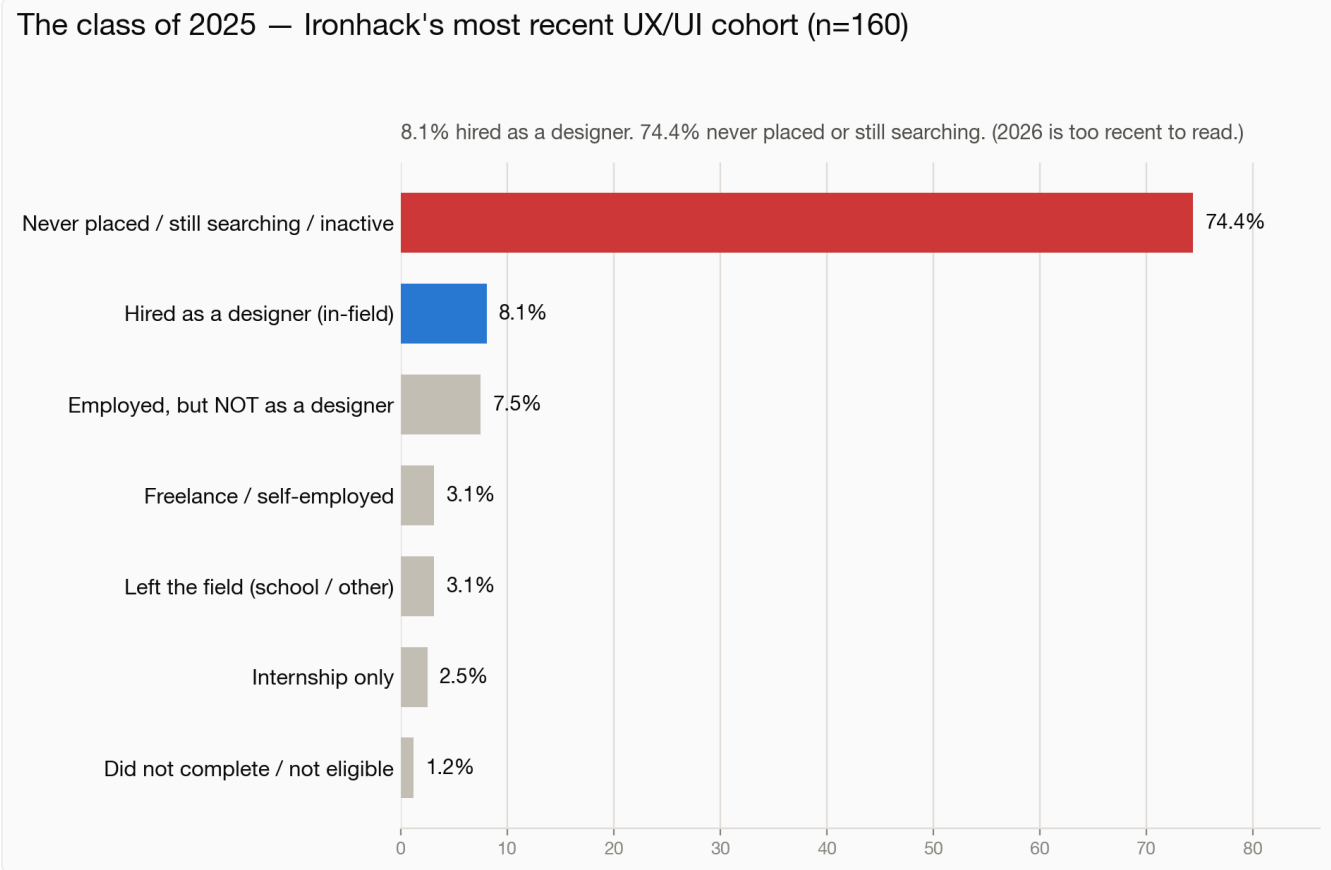
Ironhack sells its UX/UI bootcamp on placement: "*~90% of job-seeking graduates placed within 6 months*" (PwC-audited), "*96% graduation rate*", salary messaging built around a UX/UI career. This repository checks that promise against **Ironhack's own alumni-portal directory** — the internal networking/hiring directory that logged-in alumni see on `my.ironhack.com`, covering every UX/UI graduate across all 10 campuses — and finds a very different picture.

This is a data-journalism exercise built on Ironhack's own system of record. The source is not a curated public page but Ironhack's **internal alumni directory**, where each graduate's career-services outcome is logged (accessed with an alumni login). Precisely because it is the internal record and not a marketing showcase, it includes the **full spread of outcomes, failures included** — it is not cherry-picked. All results here are **aggregate and anonymous** — no individual graduate is named, and no raw personal data is republished. It does **not** allege fraud: it shows the distance between a *marketing impression* ("become a designer") and the *typical documented outcome*, using Ironhack's own status labels taken at face value.

! Latest cohort with data — the class of 2025

Of the 160 UX/UI graduates who finished in 2025, only 8.1% were hired as a designer; 74.4% were never placed or are still searching. 2025 is the most recent year with meaningful data — 2026 graduates are excluded (too recent; Ironhack has not finished recording their outcomes).

For a fully-settled comparison, the 2023 class (18+ months out, n=761) still reached only 18% hired in-field — so this is a lasting decline, not just fresh graduates.



TL;DR

Metric (all 10 campuses, n = 2,126 UX/UI grads)	Value
Hired into a salaried design role (in-field)	18.2% (386)
Never placed / still searching / inactive	45.8% (974)
Ironhack's advertised "placed" rate	~90%
Same "any job ÷ job-seekers" math, redone on this data	50.7%
Mature cohorts only (graduated ≥ 12 mo ago), hired in-field	19.2%
2023 cohort (n=761, plenty of time), hired in-field	18.0%

Fewer than 1 in 5 graduates ended up as a working designer. The advertised "~90% placed" is real only under a narrow definition of *who counts* (job-seekers only) and a broad definition of *what "placed" means* (any job at all — including non-design roles and returning to a former employer). And outcomes are **getting worse every cohort**.

What Ironhack promises

- **"We placed 90% of job-seeking graduates within 6 months"** — PwC-audited outcomes report.
- **76% placed within 90 days, 89% within 180 days**, across a reported cohort of 829 graduates (322 of them UX/UI).
- **96% graduation rate.**
- Salary messaging pointing at UX/UI pay (Ironhack's own salary blog cites averages such as **€25–35k in Spain, €42k in Germany**; US outcomes materials have cited roughly **\$65k** starting).

Two words carry the claim: **"job-seeking"** (the denominator) and **"placed"** (never defined as *in-field*). The alumni directory lets us see what those words hide.

Method

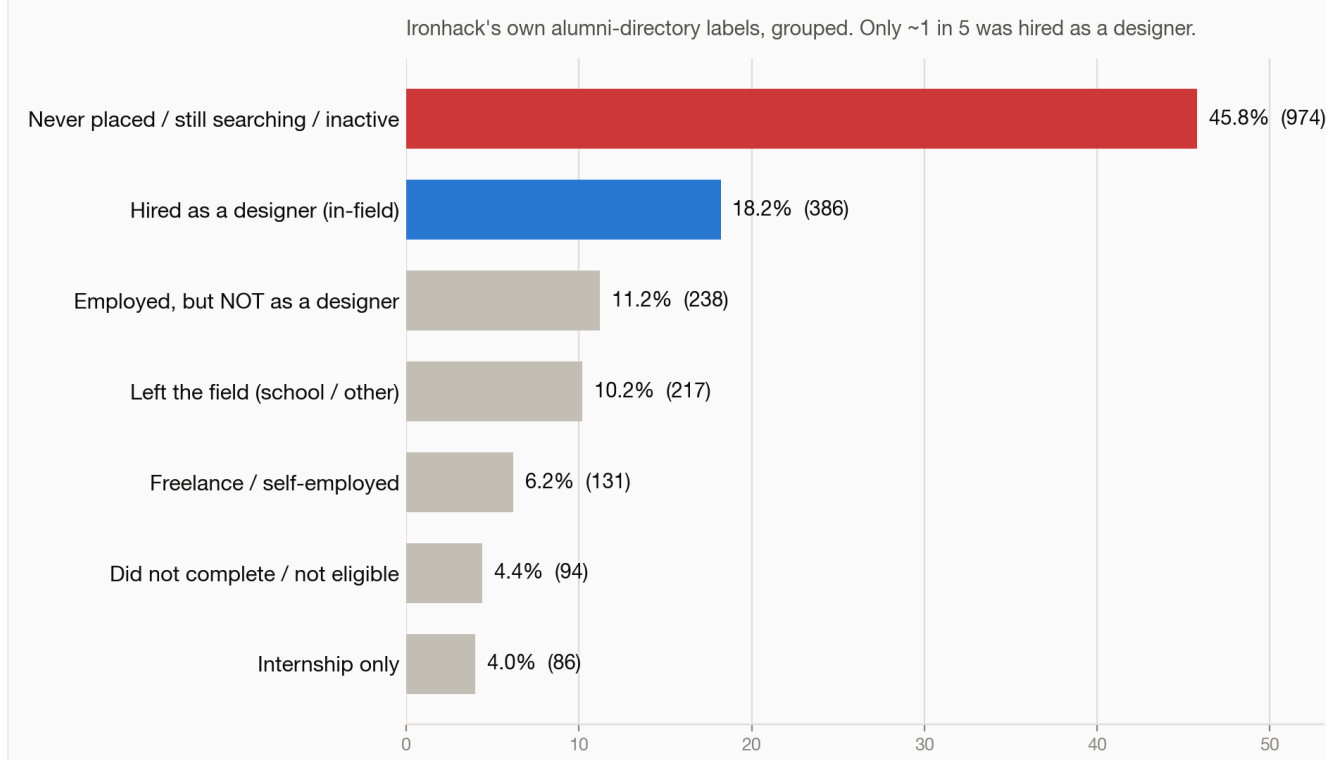
- **Source:** `POST my.ironhack.com/api/alumni` — Ironhack's alumni-portal directory, the internal record logged-in alumni browse (accessed here with an alumni login). Each record carries Ironhack's own `career_services.status` label. This is Ironhack's system of record, not a public marketing page, so it reports the real outcome distribution including failures.
- **Scope:** every UX/UI (`track=ux`) graduate the directory exposes, across **all 10 campuses — n = 2,126**.
- **Ground truth:** we take Ironhack's own status labels at face value and group them into plain-language buckets. We invent nothing. The full raw-label → bucket mapping is in the [appendix](#).
- **Recency control:** graduates from the last ~12 months are naturally still "searching," so we report **mature cohorts** (≥ 12 months out, n = 1,999) and a full **year-by-year** breakdown separately.
- **Privacy:** all published outputs are counts. Names, photos, and LinkedIn URLs stayed on the analyst's machine and are git-ignored (see [Ethics & privacy](#)).

1. What actually happened

Grouping Ironhack's own labels for all 2,126 UX/UI graduates:

Outcome (Ironhack's own labels, grouped)	Count	Share
Never placed / still searching / inactive	974	45.8%
Hired into a salaried design role (in-field)	386	18.2%
Employed, but not as a designer	238	11.2%
Left the field (back to school / other)	217	10.2%
Freelance / self-employed	131	6.2%
Did not complete / not eligible	94	4.4%
Internship only	86	4.0%

What actually happened to 2,126 Ironhack UX/UI graduates



The single most common raw label is `placement_not_successful` — **584 people, 27.5% of everyone**. More graduates went **back to a previous (non-design) job** (138) or **back to university** (120) than the marketing would suggest. Twenty-four ended up **working at Ironhack itself** (`ironhack_employee`).

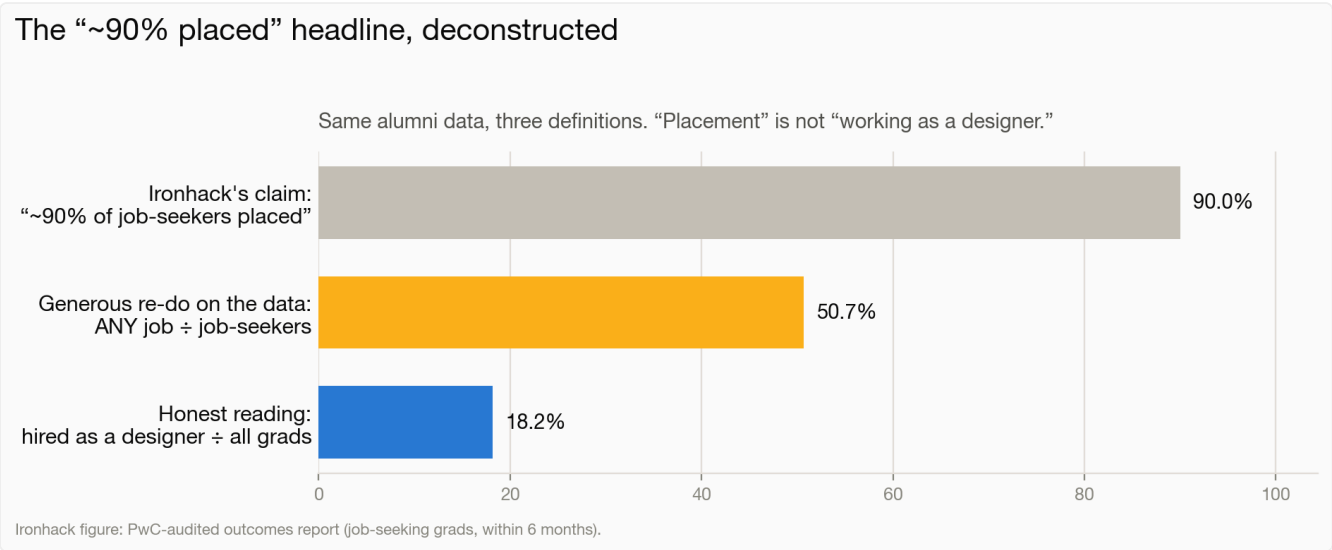
2. How the "~90% placed" headline is manufactured

We can reconstruct Ironhack's generous framing from the same data:

1. **Shrink the denominator.** Drop everyone not "job-seeking" — inactive, back-to-school, didn't-complete, personal development, withdrew. That removes ~470 people (2,126 → 1,660).
2. **Widen the numerator.** Count **any** employment as a "placement" — in-field, out-of-field, freelance, entrepreneur, internship, or returning to a former employer (841 people).

Even doing **both**, the best we reach is:

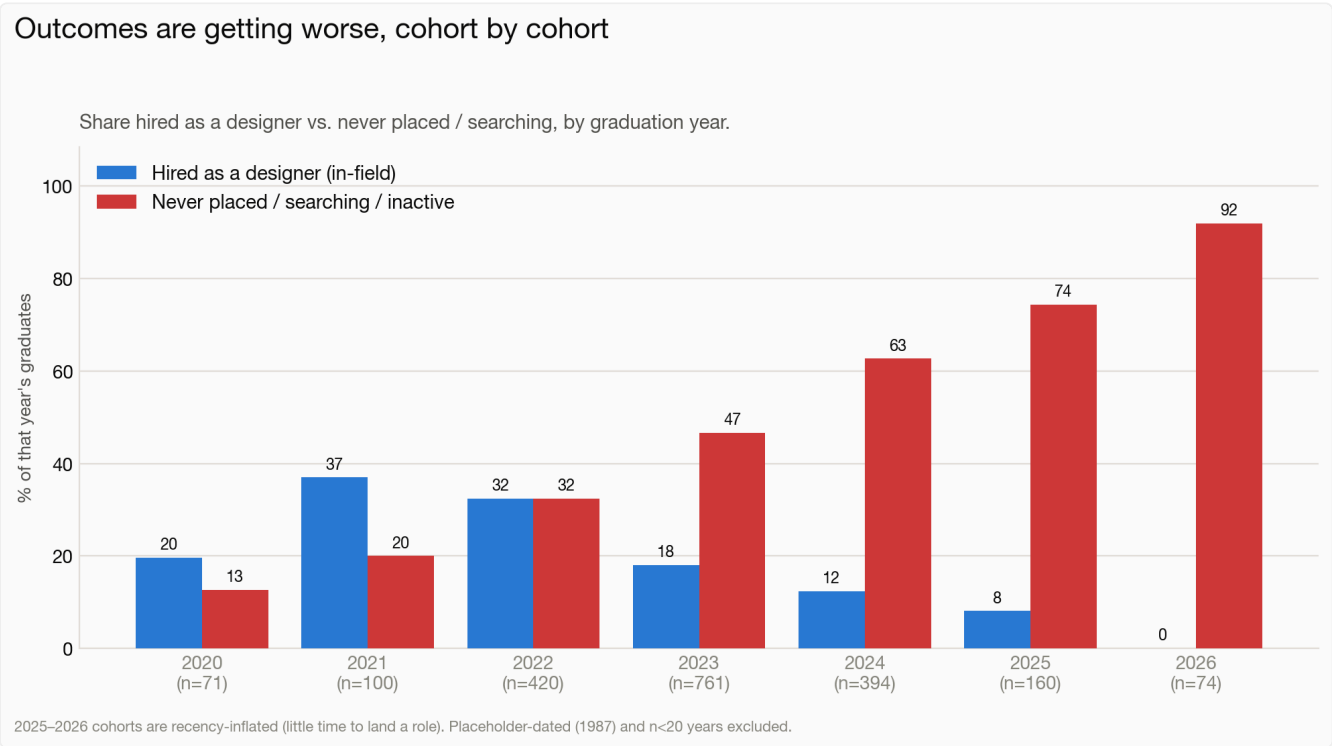
Metric	Result
Ironhack-style "placed" (any job ÷ job-seekers), all cohorts	50.7%
Same, mature cohorts only	53.7%
Honest headline: hired as a designer ÷ all graduates	18.2%



So even bending the definitions as far as they'll go, this population lands around **50%, not 90%**. The remaining gap is what "PwC-audited" quietly absorbs: a specific, time-boxed, self-reported reporting cohort — not the full body of alumni Ironhack tracks and displays. The crucial takeaway for a prospective student: **"placement" ≠ "working as a designer."**

3. Outcomes by graduation year — the collapse

This is the part the single headline hides. Splitting by graduation year shows the in-field hire rate **falling cohort after cohort** while "never placed" **balloons**:



Newest cohorts first:

Year	n	Hired in-field	Not as designer	Freelance	Never placed	Left field	Incomplete	Internship
2026	74	0.0%	4.1%	1.4%	91.9%	1.4%	0.0%	1.4%
2025	160	8.1%	7.5%	3.1%	74.4%	3.1%	1.2%	2.5%
2024	394	12.4%	8.1%	2.5%	62.7%	3.8%	5.6%	4.8%
2023	761	18.0%	11.4%	7.9%	46.6%	6.2%	5.8%	4.1%
2022	420	32.4%	9.5%	7.9%	32.4%	7.4%	4.5%	6.0%
2021	100	37.0%	12.0%	10.0%	20.0%	14.0%	1.0%	6.0%
2020	71	19.7%	22.5%	8.5%	12.7%	32.4%	4.2%	0.0%
2019	13	0.0%	23.1%	7.7%	15.4%	53.8%	0.0%	0.0%

Two things are happening at once, and both matter:

- **Recency** inflates "never placed" for **2025–2026** (those grads have barely had time to land a role) — so don't read too much into the last two bars.
- But the **decline is real and predates recency**. The **2023 cohort (n=761)** graduated 1.5–3 years ago — ample time — and still only **18%** are hired in-field, with **47% never placed**. The **2022** peak (32%) already halved by 2023. This tracks the well-documented 2023+ contraction in the junior-designer job market: a bootcamp certificate that may have worked in 2021 stopped working.

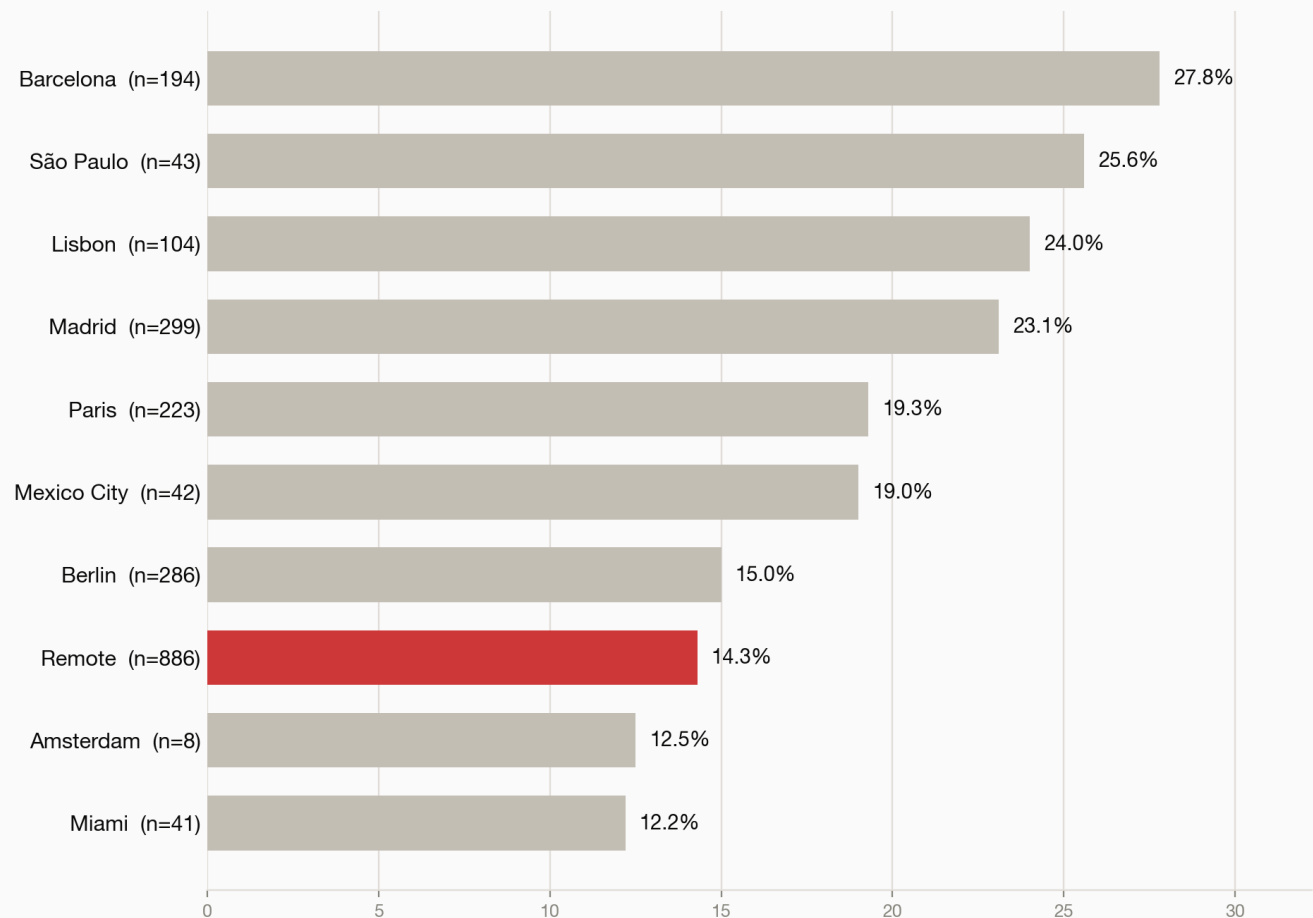
(Table is newest-first. 2019 (n=13, italic) is shown but too small to weight; the 133 placeholder-dated 1987 records are a missing-date artefact, not a real cohort — both are excluded from the chart above. See [data quality](#).)

4. Outcomes by campus

The in-field hire rate varies sharply by campus — and the **Remote** program, also the **largest** (886 grads, 42% of the dataset), is among the **worst**:

Hired as a designer, by campus

Even the best campus tops out near 28%. The heavily-marketed Remote track (largest cohort) is worst.



Amsterdam n=8 — too small to read into.

Campus	n	Hired in-field	Never placed / searching
Barcelona	194	27.8%	36.1%
São Paulo	43	25.6%	34.9%
Lisbon	104	24.0%	22.1%
Madrid	299	23.1%	20.7%
Paris	223	19.3%	42.6%
Mexico City	42	19.0%	26.2%
Berlin	286	15.0%	55.6%
Remote	886	14.3%	59.1%
Amsterdam	8	12.5%	0.0%
Miami	41	12.2%	36.6%

Even the **best** campus (Barcelona) tops out at ~28% hired in-field. (*Amsterdam n=8 is too small to read into.*)

5. The full detail: campus × graduation year

Crossing both dimensions shows exactly **where and when** the bootcamp ever worked. Cells with a reliable sample ($n \geq 20$) are coloured by in-field rate; small-sample cells ($n < 20$, shown grey in the chart / *italic* in the table) are too noisy to read.

Hired-as-a-designer rate, campus × graduation year

Darker = higher in-field rate. Grey cells have n<20 (too small to read). Blank = no graduates.

	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Remote (886)		38% n=8	24% n=123	16% n=322	14% n=211	8% n=148	0% n=74
Madrid (299)	31% n=13	36% n=14	51% n=57	41% n=69	38% n=8	0% n=3	
Berlin (286)	9% n=11	54% n=11	19% n=53	14% n=133	11% n=66	11% n=9	
Paris (223)	0% n=7	38% n=29	36% n=64	8% n=84	5% n=38		
Barcelona (194)	15% n=13	50% n=8	49% n=45	27% n=78	10% n=49		
Lisbon (104)	100% n=2	33% n=6	46% n=22	16% n=55	10% n=19		
São Paulo (43)	27% n=11	40% n=10	18% n=22				
Mexico City (42)	40% n=5	12% n=8	21% n=24				
Miami (41)	0% n=5	0% n=3	30% n=10	5% n=20	33% n=3		
Amsterdam (8)	0% n=4	33% n=3					

Row label shows each campus's total n. Even the strongest cells rarely clear 50%, and they erode after 2022.

In-field hire rate — % (n) per cell (*italic = n < 20, small sample; — = no graduates that year*):

Campus (total n)	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Remote (886)	—	38% (8)	24% (123)	16% (322)	14% (211)	8% (148)	0% (74)
Madrid (299)	31% (13)	36% (14)	51% (57)	41% (69)	38% (8)	0% (3)	—
Berlin (286)	9% (11)	54% (11)	19% (53)	14% (133)	11% (66)	11% (9)	—
Paris (223)	0% (7)	38% (29)	36% (64)	8% (84)	5% (38)	—	—
Barcelona (194)	15% (13)	50% (8)	49% (45)	27% (78)	10% (49)	—	—
Lisbon (104)	100% (2)	33% (6)	46% (22)	16% (55)	10% (19)	—	—
São Paulo (43)	27% (11)	40% (10)	18% (22)	—	—	—	—
Mexico City (42)	40% (5)	12% (8)	21% (24)	—	—	—	—
Miami (41)	0% (5)	0% (3)	30% (10)	5% (20)	33% (3)	—	—
Amsterdam (8)	0% (4)	33% (3)	—	—	—	—	—

Even the strongest, best-sampled cells — **Madrid 2022 (51%, n=57)**, **Barcelona 2022 (49%, n=45)**, **Madrid 2023 (41%, n=69)** — barely reach a coin-flip, and only at the 2022 peak. By 2023–2024 every well-sampled campus has collapsed into the teens (Remote 16→14%, Berlin 14→11%, Paris 8→5%, Barcelona 27→10%). The bootcamp's best years are behind it, on every campus at once.

(The matching never-placed cross-tab is in `data/report_all.json` under `per_campus_year`.)

6. The "freelance" question

A common suspicion is that "freelance UX designer" is often a polite label for *couldn't find a salaried role*. In this data, freelance is a **small** group — **89 people, 4.2%** (131, 6.2%, if you fold in `entrepreneur`) — so it is **not** the main story. But it is strikingly **long-tenured**: the median freelancer graduated **40 months** ago, and **88 of 89** have been freelance for **24+ months**. That is consistent with (though not proof of) freelancing being a durable destination rather than a short bridge to employment.

7. Even the "success" bucket is inflated

The 18% "hired in-field" figure is itself an *overcount*. In at least one case the authors can personally verify, a graduate labelled `hired_in_field` was, in reality:

- **already employed before enrolling** — the role predates the bootcamp entirely, and
- **working as a Product Manager, not a designer**, at a **pre-existing employer**.

Ironhack still books that person as a UX/UI "designer hired in field." If the flagship success label absorbs people who were already employed, in a different role, before they started, then the true "*became a working designer because of Ironhack*" rate sits **below** the 18% headline.

Provenance & tamper-evidence

Can we prove we actually fetched this from Ironhack, that the numbers weren't altered, and that the proof survives if Ironhack later deletes the directory? Largely yes. The capture is hashed into a Merkle root and that root is **signed by an independent RFC 3161 timestamp authority**, which freezes it in time — after that, no deletion or edit on Ironhack's side can change what we can prove the endpoint returned on the capture date. Cloudflare `cf-ray` headers and the live TLS certificate are captured as corroboration. Full threat model, honest limitations (transferable origin needs TLSNotary/zkTLS), and step-by-step verification are in [PROVENANCE.md](#).

The "high-paid" part

This dataset records employment **status**, not pay, so it cannot directly verify "high-paid." But it doesn't need to: if only ~18% are employed **as designers at all**, the "high-paid designer" promise is moot for the other ~82%. Ironhack's own salary blog, meanwhile, cites European UX/UI averages in the €25–42k range — modest, and irrelevant to the majority who never enter the field.

Data quality notes

- **Placeholder dates.** 133 Madrid records share the exact date `1987-12-04T00:00:00Z` — a missing-date sentinel, not a real 1987 cohort. They skew toward `back_to_university` / `back_to_job`. They are **kept** in the population totals (their status labels are valid) but **excluded** from the year-by-year chart.
- **Labels are Ironhack's.** We don't know Ironhack's precise internal definition of `placement_not_successful`, or how aggressively `searching` / `inactive` are refreshed.
- **Snapshot in time** (scraped July 2026).
- **Directory ≠ census.** It may not contain 100% of graduates — but as Ironhack's internal record it *does* include failures, drop-outs, and `withdrew`, so it is not a cherry-picked success reel; if anything it undercounts the worst outcomes (people who vanish entirely).
- **Access.** The directory sits behind the `my.ironhack.com` alumni login; it is not a public web page. The figures here are Ironhack's own; only aggregate, anonymous counts are republished (see *Ethics & privacy*).

Limitations

- Employment **status only**, not salary or seniority.
- **UX/UI track only** — web-dev and data tracks are not covered.
- Self-reported / possibly stale profiles.
- Recency affects the 2025–2026 cohorts (addressed via the mature-cohort cut and the year table).

Appendix A — full status enumeration (all 24 labels)

Every distinct `career_services.status` value in the data, with the bucket it maps to. Nothing is dropped; the buckets are exhaustive and mutually exclusive.

Raw label	Count	%	Bucket
placement_not_successful	584	27.5%	Never placed / searching / inactive
hired_in_field	386	18.2%	Salaried designer (in-field)
searching	163	7.7%	Never placed / searching / inactive
back_to_job	138	6.5%	Job, not as a designer
inactive	129	6.1%	Never placed / searching / inactive
back_to_university	120	5.6%	Left the field
freelance	89	4.2%	Freelance / self-employed
personal_development	83	3.9%	Left the field
hired_out_of_field	76	3.6%	Job, not as a designer
not_graduated_cs	71	3.3%	Did not complete / not eligible
internship	68	3.2%	Internship only
intervention_careers	45	2.1%	Never placed / searching / inactive
entrepreneur	42	2.0%	Freelance / self-employed
intervention_education	25	1.2%	Never placed / searching / inactive
ironhack_employee	24	1.1%	Job, not as a designer
not_eligible	23	1.1%	Did not complete / not eligible
short_term	18	0.8%	Internship only
deferred_more_than_45d	14	0.7%	Never placed / searching / inactive
withdrew	14	0.7%	Left the field
intervention_careers_not_success	5	0.2%	Never placed / searching / inactive
pending	4	0.2%	Never placed / searching / inactive
deferred_less_than_45d	3	0.1%	Never placed / searching / inactive
deferred_more_than_45d_sc	1	0.0%	Never placed / searching / inactive
intervention_education_not_success	1	0.0%	Never placed / searching / inactive

Reproduce

```
# 1. Log in to the Ironhack alumni portal (requires an alumni account), then copy a
# fresh x-csrf-token from the Network tab. It is short-lived.
export IRONHACK_CSRF="<token>"
```

```
# 2. Scrape every campus (ux track).
for c in rmt par mad bcn ber mia lis ams sao mex; do
  python3 scrape.py --track ux --campus "$c"
done
```

```
# 3. Aggregate + chart.
python3 analyze_all.py      # -> data/report_all.json + console tables
python3 make_charts.py     # -> assets/*.png
```

Files

File	What it is
scrape.py	Collects the alumni-portal directory into local JSONL + CSV (token via <code>IRONHACK_CSRF</code> env)
analyze.py	Single-campus aggregate stats
analyze_all.py	Combined analysis across all campuses → <code>data/report_all.json</code>
make_charts.py	Renders the five infographics in <code>assets/</code>
capture.py	Tamper-evident capture: saves raw response bytes + Cloudflare headers
provenance.py	Builds <code>provenance/manifest.json</code> (SHA-256 + Merkle root + TLS/CF witness)
PROVENANCE.md	How we attest the fetch & non-alteration, and its limits
<code>data/report_all.json</code>	The aggregate, anonymous result set (counts only)
<code>assets/*.png</code>	The charts

Ethics & privacy

- The source is **Ironhack's own alumni-portal directory**, accessed with an alumni login — Ironhack's internal system of record, not a public page.
- **Nothing identifying is republished.** All published outputs are **aggregate and anonymous** counts. Raw per-person data (names, LinkedIn URLs, photos) is **git-ignored** and never leaves the analyst's machine. The purpose is the public interest of prospective students weighing the bootcamp's marketing claims against its own recorded outcomes.
- **Verification on request.** The underlying raw capture — hashed and RFC 3161-timestamped (see [PROVENANCE.md](#)) — **can be provided on request to legitimate funding or oversight bodies** (e.g. public training funders) for independent verification.
- Status labels are **Ironhack's own**, taken at face value. This is a comparison between a marketing impression and the typical documented outcome — not an allegation of fraud. See *Limitations* and *Data quality notes* above.

License

Underlying data is Ironhack's; the analysis, code, and charts here are released under the MIT License.